



People often tell you that when you're pregnant **your life** will take on new meaning—but you may also be **wondering** how life will change on a more **day-to-day** basis now that you're expecting. There's a lot you can do to give you and your baby the **best possible chance** of enjoying a healthy, safe, and manageable pregnancy.

Lifestyle changes

The world around you

Now that you are pregnant you may be more conscious than ever before of how the environment we live and work in has a direct impact on our health and well-being, and you may wonder how it affects your developing baby's health and well-being, too. In this chapter we'll look at some of the questions you might have about the environment you live in and the chemicals you come into contact with and how you can minimize their effects (if there are any) on your own and your unborn baby's health. We consider the effects of air pollution if you live in a city and exposure to toxic heavy metals, and what to do if you have lead water pipes in your house.

The world of work

How pregnancy affects your working life will depend on the type of work that you do. In this section, we look at any aspects of your job that might be hazardous to your unborn baby or particularly debilitating for you while you're pregnant, so that you can take steps to protect yourself and your growing baby during this important time. We'll also investigate what maternity benefits you,

and also your partner, may be eligible to receive through your employer since more companies today are offering paternity leave to their male employees. We'll also discuss other benefits that you may be eligible for if your company doesn't offer employees paid maternity leave.

Lifestyle matters

We'll look at issues such as pets, the cosmetics you use, and leisure activities such as gardening. We'll answer some of the most commonly asked questions to guide you on where to make changes in your lifestyle. We'll put your mind at ease where you might have concerns. We all need our rest and probably no one needs it more than an expectant mother. Perhaps you want to take a vacation before your baby is born—how late can you fly? What happens if you need vaccinations? How can you make car travel comfortable? What vacation insurance coverage should you get? Finally, we'll take a look at sleep—more precious now than it might ever have been. How can you make sure that you get all the rest you need when being pregnant? We suggest the best time to sleep and how to limit naps to your body's natural sleep cycle.